

WITCHCRAFT ACADEMY

Written by

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COLD OPEN

EXT. OPEN FIELD WITH BIG WILLOW TREE - DAY

The initially calm and soothing open field starts to bring an eerie sensation as we zoom in closer to the willow roots. The screaming of cicadas starts growing louder as we watch one struggling to free itself from the mud. As it finally frees itself, it flies and land on the willow tree, then thousands of cicadas follow the same pattern as the sound becomes almost unbearable. Dolly zoom out as we see the tree infested by thousand of screaming cicadas.

ACT ONE - AWAKENING

INT. WILLOW'S ROOM - MORNING

Black screen. The cicada sound transformed into the alarm sound. WILLOW, 21F, hits the clock and the noise stops. A buzzing sound, as after an explosion remains. The darkness slowly gives way to the 360 panning view of her room that stops once centered on her face sitting on the bed. She rests her face on her hands and stays there for a second. She squeezes her own arm in a sort of silent pep talk and gets up heading to the bathroom.

WILLOW (V.O.)

I hate this feeling I get in the mornings... As if a whole building was left on top of my chest. The dizziness, the cold sweaty hands, the rushing heart. This sucks. Every time, so nauseous.

INT. BATHROOM

WILLOW washes her face. Brushes her teeth and then her dry curly hair. It slowly loses its defined curls and turns into a wavy voluminous mess. She's on routine mode, as her face and her eyes can't help but show her sadness. She turns around, glimpse at the camera, as of telling us to shush, as if we know her secrets. She then leaves the bathroom and screams

WILLOW

The bathroom's free!!

INT. KITCHEN

WILLOW comes in and grabs an apple that she starts eating. Her mother, AVA, 45F, is cooking scrambled eggs and looks away from the stove and towards WILLOW for a moment.

AVA

WILLOW! You can't go out like that.
Go brush your hair.

WILLOW

I already did!

WILLOW is clearly annoyed, almost exhausted.

WILLOW TALKING HEAD

WILLOW (CONT'D)

This sucks! The more I brush my
hair, the more it gets frizzy, and
it's not my fault I don't have
perfectly straight hair as mother
and AYA.

AVA TALKING HEAD

AVA

She's so difficult. She can't even
be properly presentable for her
mother. After everything I did...
You know I only stayed with my
abusive husband because of those
little rats. Well that's what you
get...

CAMERA MAN

Don't you think it is dangerous for
kids to grow up living with an
aggressive unstable father?

AVA

What?... No. You're missing the
point. They are FINE! I'm the one
that is mistreated and who no one
cares about, you know when I was a
kid my mom...

BACK TO SCENE

AYA, 24F, comes into the kitchen and sits down at the table
with a cereal bowl.

AYA

Does the coffee has sugar?

AVA

Not that one, you can drink it
honey.

AYA
Thanks mommy. Where's the
sweetener?

WILLOW glances at the camera.

AVA
Oh, it's over here.

AVA handles her the sweetener. AYA sees WILLOW with her apple intact in hand.

AYA
WILLOW, is that all you're eating?

WILLOW
Uh... I guess...

She looks down at the apple in her hands. Stomach hurls.

AYA
Aren't you hungry? How do you do
that?

WILLOW
Not really. I don't know... it's just
early

Her stomach hurling. Her body asking for food. Her face refusing it. She takes a bite. Her stomach turns and the food comes back. She swallows it, trying to be discreet.

AYA
Mommy!! That's so unfairrrr. Why
does she get to be skinny and
doesn't feel hungry and I get to be
the hungry fat one? It's soo
unfair!

AVA
AYA! Stop with that, you're both
beautiful. You just have to put in
more effort.

AVA (CONT'D)
Now, why'd you stop with the gym?

WILLOW glances at the camera quickly as she gets up and leaves the house.

EXT. PUBLIC PARK

WILLOW TALKING HEAD

WILLOW

Hey! I'm sorry for that. I never understood why they are so fixated on their weight. They both look fine to me. I wish I looked like that.

WILLOW is seated underneath the big tree that shares her name. She takes a notebook from her backpack and starts writing. Even though the park is empty, she seems to be hiding whatever is being written.

WILLOW (V.O.)

Today was the usual, I just got to the park and ANNA should be here any moment now. It's been so long since we had any alone time. I can't wait to see her. I have this plan, I saved up from my barista gig and now I have enough to buy us an used van. We can get it running and get out of this place. For good.

ANNA, 21F, jumps beside WILLOW, distracted with her notebook, in an attempt to scare her.

ANNA

BUH!!!

WILLOW

ANNA!! Finallyyy.

She hugs Anna and roll her over the grass. Now with Anna above her, her face blushes as her smile cheek to cheek can't be contained.

ANNA

It's been getting harder and harder since my mom walked in on us. I'm sorry.

WILLOW

Don't be. It's not your fault.

WILLOW reaches out for her phone, with a cheeky expression of who's got a surprise

WILLOW (CONT'D)

But I've got the solution right here.

ANNA

Oh yeah? What is it, a brainwashing device?

WILLOW pulls up a van announce and shows ANNA.

WILLOW

No! It's better. It's our way out I've saved enough money for us to leave this place. We can buy this van, build our own motorhome and drive away

ANNA's face is still. No excitement.

ANNA

What do you mean WILLOW? We can't leave.

WILLOW

Why not? This place has always made it clear we don't belong. Let's just build home somewhere else

ANNA

WILLOW... This place may be awful to us, but it's still my home

WILLOW

So what? All the times I said I would leave this place, you would just let me leave? You never meant to go with me?

ANNA

I don't know what to say... That has never been something realistic

WILLOW

Realistic?? You sound just like my mother. I can't believe you're leaving me too

ANNA

WILLOW you couldn't have just assumed...

WILLOW gets up, throws her stuff in the backpack.

WILLOW

It's fine. I get it now. Bye ANNA.

WILLOW storms off.

INT. WILLOW'S ROOM

WILLOW storms in, fist closed, she hits the wall one, two... she stops. She hears this voice in her mind. Smooth and angelic.

ANGELIC VOICE (V.O.)
What's wrong child?

WILLOW
I just can't take it anymore.

She starts sobbing with her hands covering her face.

WILLOW (CONT'D)
I feel like I give so much of myself, and there's never anything good left for me.

ANGELIC VOICE (V.O.)
I get why this is so stressful for you... And so do you. You've always known.

WILLOW
What's the point of knowing what's wrong if I don't have any power to change it? If everyone leaves me?

ANGELIC VOICE (V.O.)
Not everyone. I'm here for you. And as long as you're focused on me, and not to those other thoughts, you'll be fine. But first you need to remain calm.

WILLOW feels a wave of calmness taking over her, with this soothing voice that shows so much care for her. And when she realizes the voice is no longer there and she's feeling calm and finally thinking straight. She looks over her desk and sees the Yoruba book her auntie had given her. She goes to that page which had been calling her. She lights candle by candle, saying Yoruba greetings for each and every Orisha. She adds the glass of water to the altar, along with the plants she harvested earlier. She gets on her knees and touch her forehead in the ground three times saying

WILLOW
Laroye Esu, Mojuba

And then, still on her knees, she starts praying whatever she feels weights her heart. She pours out her soul until she starts feeling enraged again. She starts chanting.

WILLOW (CONT'D)
I can read people's mind
My power is but mine
I can read people's mind
Let the universe align

A rush of wind blows some of the candles. All windows and doors are closed. The wind stills. The remaining candles flicker and rise.

WILLOW open her eyes. Something has changed. Every sound in the house seems closer. Too close. Louder. Too loud.

She can hear them.

INT. KITCHEN

AVA
Where's WILLOW? Why can't we just
be a united family?

AYA
Uh... I bet she's upstairs texting
her girlfriend

AVA
Hell no! She promised to stop with
that crap

LARRY
God, I just pray she snaps out of
this phase and live a normal life

AVA TALKING HEAD

AVA
You know she's not ACTUALLY lesbian
right? She's just doing that to
embarrass me.

WILLOW (V.O.)
What the fuck? How can you be so
self-centered?

AYA TALKING HEAD

AYA
If they're still talking? Oh, I
don't know. She doesn't tell me
anything these days... Figures

WILLOW (V.O.)
Guess why? You literally
blackmailed to out me

LARRY TALKING HEAD

LARRY, 55M, sits down trying to project confidence. He stares into the camera as if it's a children's game and who speaks first will lose. He makes some faces to project that he's winning. He only seems childish and foolish.

ACT TWO - THE CROSSROAD

INT. WILLOW'S ROOM

WILLOW is covering her ears on the floor as she and the audience is buried with her family thoughts. Dolly zoom in her face, as her hair starts flying around. She looks at the windows and doors, that are still closed. Her eyes open wide, freaked out by what's clearly gone beyond her control. Her eyes watering as the papers in her desk start flying around the room and she begins hearing screams coming from downstairs.

AVA (V.O.)
WHAT THE HELL IS GOING ON? WHAT IS
THIS WIND COMING FROM?

AYA (V.O.)
AAAAHHHHHH!!! MY HAIR!!!! SOMEONE
STOP THIS !!!!!

LARRY (V.O.)
STOP SCREAMING. GOD DAMN IT!

She runs to the door and as she opens it and look downstairs, a powerful wind opens the front door wide open, revealing, OYAMI, a gorgeous woman with the imposing presence of a goddess. She glances and nod at the family standing in the kitchen, still confused as the wind settles down. OYAMI goes halfway up the stairs and look at WILLOW as if they'd known each other their whole lives.

OYAMI
Hey there, kid. You got yourself
into quite a mess huh?

She glances around the papers laying on the floor.

WILLOW

What have I done? I'm sorry! Help me! Please.

OYAMI comes closer. Lays her hand on WILLOW's head.

OYAMI

Kid, relax. You're like the fifth rescue just today.

AVA

Rescue? No one need no rescuing here ma'am. You can move along.

OYAMI

Like you'd know shit. Oya don't miss and she's on quite a streak today.

AVA's face turns into fear as she hears the name of Oya. She looks at AYA and AYA is looking back at her. LARRY holds the face of anger and storms in front of OYAMI.

LARRY

Where do you think you are? This is my house. You're leaving now!

OYAMI makes a slight gesture with her right hand and he's pushed towards the wall by the wind, he falls unconscious. She looks back at WILLOW, nods her head signaling her to come along, and goes towards the door.

WILLOW

How can I stop hearing their thoughts?

OYAMI

Oof... That's a way to get you started. Honey, you're waking up, it's okay. We'll help you through it. Didn't you ask for help?

WILLOW

YES!! How do we revert this?

OYAMI

How we- Hahaha sorry kid, that's not how it works. I need to take you to training now.

WILLOW

Training? For what?

OYAMI

For your powers. But we must go quickly.

WILLOW

But... what about my family?

OYAMI

They'll be fine. Weren't you looking for a way out?

WILLOW

Uhhh...

WILLOW seems divided. She looks at AVA. Then AYA.

AYA (V.O.)

WHAT? Can't she see I'm the special one?

AVA (V.O.)

Who does she think WILLOW is? Of course she won't leave us

WILLOW face shifts. She seems older. Decided.

WILLOW

Okay. Let's go.

They walk out the door, when WILLOW turns to close the door she stops for a second looking at AYA.

WILLOW (CONT'D)

Did you forget I could hear your thoughts this whole time?

Door closes.

CUT TO BLACK.

Witchcraft Academy is a half-hour mockumentary following WILLOW BENNET, a 21-year-old queer African-American woman, whose desperate prayer sparks the inner magic realm. Daughter of Oya, goddess of the winds and changes, she receives an unconventional visit from OYAMI, an elder witch from the same mother. Pulled from her dysfunctional family and limiting environments, she joins a class with many other initiates. Each one must choose their coven of four. She quickly bonds with Lily, daughter of Oshun, Maria, daughter of Yemanja and Flora, daughter of Nana. The first episodes summarize each of their paths that all converge to the Witchcraft Academy. Together they navigate the exploration of their powers, their new found independence and identities.

The hardest challenge will be to detach from the mental obstacles they have ingrained as to who they are and what is possible, when coming in touch with the alchemy of co-creation.